

We've been discussing the free will defense as a response to the argument from evil. This response assumes something about us: that we have free will.

But what does this mean?

To say that we have free will is to say that some of our actions are up to us; it to say that, at least sometimes, we have the ability to choose what we do.

Is it true that some of our actions are up to us, and that we sometimes are able to choose what we will do?

This is the question we'll be asking ourselves for the next two weeks. Our discussion will involve us considering the three strongest arguments **against** the view that we have free will.

But before doing that it is worth asking why there is any reason to accept the common view that we do have free will. Are there any arguments in favor of the reality of free will?

There are. The first argument starts with an apparent fact about moral responsibility: it seems (at least to a first approximation) that we are only responsible for actions which we freely perform. If you find out that someone's action was not done of their own free will, then it would be odd to blame them for their action.

But it also seems that people are at least sometimes genuinely responsible for their actions.

This suggests the following simple argument:

THE ARGUMENT FROM MORAL RESPONSIBILITY

1. If someone's action is not free, and did not stem from an action which was free, then they are not responsible for that action.
2. We are all responsible for at least some of our actions.

C. At least some of our actions are free.

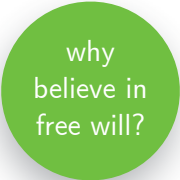
How should someone who does not believe in free will respond?



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

responsibilities about what we have free will.

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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

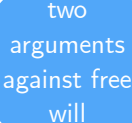
So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



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Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

for fatalsn.

first let's think about how Edwards'

We'll shortly consider some ways of

responding to Edwards' argument. But

argument might be related to an argument

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

similar to Edwards' argument?

there were truths about all our future

actions. Could they give an argument

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Suppose that someone did not believe in

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about



1. We have no direct facts.

God knows that in the future I will

acaioid.

then we have the choice about q.

all of our activities.

5* We have not noticed that fact

some action, then I will prefer that

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

perform a certain action (1,2)

will perform various actions.

3 We have not the fact that

that if it is true that I will perform



4. If we have no choice about p , and no

0 We have achieved what we

(3, 4, 5)

2*In the past, there were truths about

The fatalist argument



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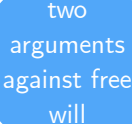
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